Low-Code Experiment

Deploying a Zoho Creator Application from Development to Production Environment

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Abstract
This experiment documents the release flow of a Zoho Creator application through its environments. The HOTEL BOOKING application was built and tested in the Development environment, and the procedure for deploying it to Stage and then to Production is described together with the evidence available in the lab account.

1. Aim
To deploy a Zoho Creator application from the Development environment to the Stage and then the Production environment.

Note on Execution
The lab account's free trial has expired (the banner Trial has expired is visible in the screenshots), and the features used in this experiment need a paid plan. The experiment is therefore documented as a procedure together with the evidence that could be captured in the available account. Steps that could not be executed are marked as such.

2. Concepts
Environments. Zoho Creator provides three environments: Development (build and test changes), Stage (test with realistic data before release) and Production (the live application used by real users). Environments were enabled for this application in Experiment 2.

Deployment. The application structure (forms, reports, workflows, pages) is promoted from one environment to the next. Each environment has its own data and its own URL, shown in the address bar as /environment/development, /environment/stage or /environment/production.

Why use them. Developers can change and test the application without disturbing live users, and a tested version is promoted unchanged.

3. Procedure
1. Build and test the application in the Development environment. Every form, report, dashboard and workflow of HOTEL BOOKING was created here, and the live view is opened with Access Development Live (executed).
2. Confirm that the address bar of the live application contains /environment/development and that the Development label is shown in the top bar (executed, Figure 2).
3. Open the deployment option of the application and choose Deploy to Stage; review the components list, add a description such as Release 1 and confirm (not executed: requires a paid plan).
4. Test the application in Stage, including the booking form and the confirmation email workflow (not executed).

5. Choose Deploy to Production from Stage and confirm, then verify the application at /environment/production (not executed).

6. Make later changes only in Development and deploy them again, so that Production stays stable between releases.

4. Implementation Screenshots (HOTEL BOOKING application)

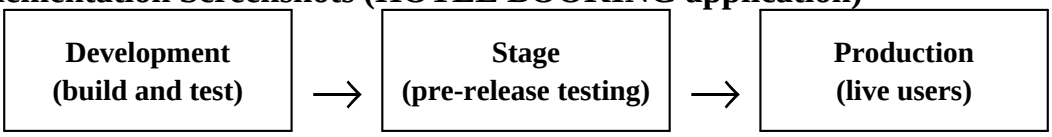


Figure 1: Release flow of Zoho Creator environments (diagram)

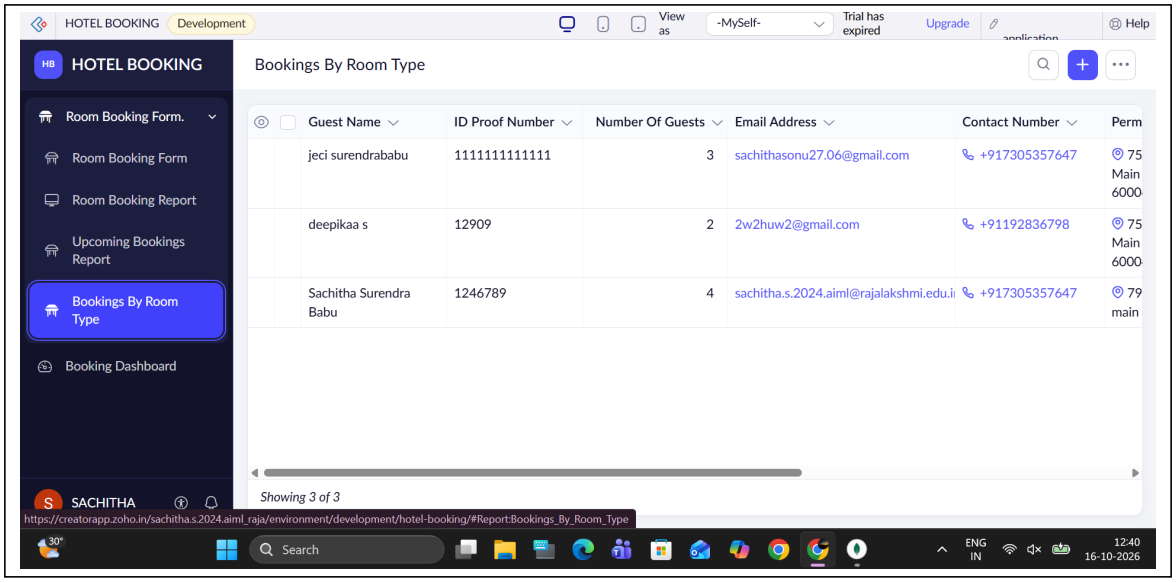


Figure 2: Bookings By Room Type live in the Development environment, with the Development label and the /environment/development address

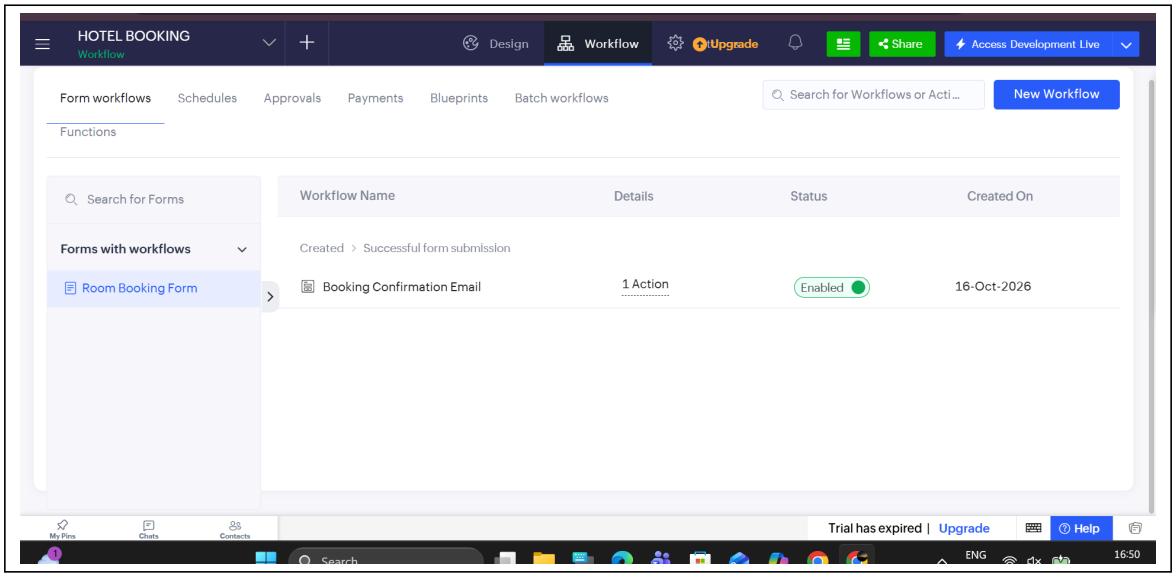


Figure 3: Workflow page of HOTEL BOOKING with the Access Development Live option

5. Expected Output

The same forms, reports, dashboard and workflow would be available in Stage and Production, each with its own URL, and later Development changes would not appear in Production until they are deployed.

6. Result

The application was built, tested and run in the Development environment, and the environment is identified in the live view by its label and URL. Deployment to Stage and Production needs a paid plan and could not be executed in the lab account, so that part is documented as the procedure above.

7. Learning Outcome

Learnt the Development, Stage and Production release flow of Zoho Creator, how each environment is identified by its URL, and why testing in Stage protects live users.